

Toddler aggression guide covering impulse control techniques and reading body language cues — Action Checklist

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UNDERSTAND THE IMPULSE CONTROL GAP

- ☐ **Understand the Impulse Control Gap:** Recognize that your toddler's hitting comes from a brain that isn't finished building impulse control yet, not from a character flaw or bad intentions.
- ☐ **Understand the Impulse Control Gap:** Reframe your toddler's hitting as a timing problem rather than a behavior problem, understanding that their brain physically cannot do what you're asking of them yet.
- ☐ **Understand the Impulse Control Gap:** Observe your child for early warning signs before hitting episodes occur, watching for hand flapping or other signals that indicate they are becoming dysregulated.
- ☐ **Understand the Impulse Control Gap:** Identify which of the four root triggers—overstimulation, frustration, physical discomfort, or attention-seeking—typically drives your child's aggression.

READ PRE-AGGRESSION BODY LANGUAGE

- ☐ **Read Pre-Aggression Body Language:** Watch your child for early warning signs like hand flapping, facial tension, or sudden withdrawal that signal aggression is building before it erupts.
- ☐ **Read Pre-Aggression Body Language:** Intervene at the earliest sign of dysregulation rather than waiting for the hit to occur, moving closer and speaking softly to interrupt the pattern.
- ☐ **Read Pre-Aggression Body Language:** Match your response to the specific trigger you identified, not applying the same generic solution to every situation your child faces.
- ☐ **Read Pre-Aggression Body Language:** Practice calm, consistent redirection when you catch the signals, saying no firmly while offering a sensory break to prevent escalation.

BUILD YOUR REGULATION SCAFFOLDING

- ☐ **Build Your Regulation Scaffolding:** Function as your child's external regulation system by staying calm and providing predictable responses that their brain cannot yet generate internally.
 - ☐ **Build Your Regulation Scaffolding:** Check your expectations before reacting to your child's behavior, asking yourself what you are expecting them to do that their brain is not yet capable of.
 - ☐ **Build Your Regulation Scaffolding:** Create sensory support strategies such as finding a quiet space, reducing noise, or offering a comfort object when overstimulation triggers aggression.
 - ☐ **Build Your Regulation Scaffolding:** Maintain your own regulation by pausing and taking a breath before responding, understanding that your calmness directly influences their ability to regulate.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.